

Echinacea spp. (Asteraceae)

Echinacea, Purple Coneflower

A key medicinal herb, echinacea has a tonic action on the body's immune system. Known by 19th-century Americans as Indian Snakeroot (due to its ability to treat snake bites), the herb has a potent ability to counter infection, especially viral and bacterial, and to aid the clearance of toxins from the body. It is commonly taken as a preventative and treatment for upper respiratory infections such as colds, flu, and coughs.



Echinacea is a name derived from the Greek word for hedgehog and was inspired by the appearance of the flower's central cone.

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to central parts of the U.S., three species of echinacea are used medicinally: *E. angustifolia*, *E. purpurea*, and *E. pallida*. All are threatened in the wild and only commercially grown plants should be used. *E. purpurea* is cultivated widely in the U.S. and Europe. Grown from seed in spring or by root division in winter, it thrives in rich, sandy soil. The leaves and flowers are gathered during flowering; the roots of 4-year-old plants are lifted in autumn.

Key Constituents

(*E. purpurea*)

- Alkylamides (mostly isobutylamides)
- Caffeic acid esters (mainly echinacoside and cynarin)
- Polysaccharides

Key Actions

- Immune modulator
- Antimicrobial
- Anti-inflammatory
- Detoxifying

- Heals wounds
- Stimulates saliva

Research

■ **Immune system** Clinical research into echinacea has confirmed that it increases the number of white blood cells and their strength of action, although its precise mode of action on immune function is not well understood. The polysaccharides inhibit the ability of viruses to take over cells, while the alkylamides are antibacterial and antifungal. Research supports the use of echinacea to prevent colds and respiratory infections resulting from air travel. Not all clinical trials have found positive effects, possibly because in some cases too low a dose of echinacea was used.

Traditional & Current uses

■ **Native American medicine** The Comanche used echinacea as a remedy for toothache and sore throats and the Sioux took it for rabies, snake bite, and septic conditions.

■ **Western uses** Echinacea is a key remedy in Western herbal medicine, and is used to treat many health problems, notably viral and fungal infections, and skin infections such as acne and boils. It makes an excellent gargle for throat infections, and is typically prescribed by herbalists wherever the immune system is underperforming.

■ **Allergies** The herb is a helpful remedy for treating allergies such as asthma.

Self-help Uses

- Acne & boils, p. 305.



Echinacea

A perennial growing to 4 ft (1.2 m) with upright stems and pink to purple daisy-like flowers.

Parts Used

Flower of *E. purpurea* is occasionally used for infections.

Roots of all three species have valuable immune-stimulating properties.



Fresh *E. purpurea* root

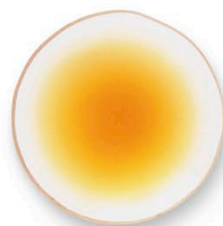


Dried root

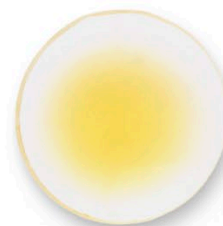
The best-quality root leaves a tingling sensation on the tongue

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Caution** Can cause allergic reactions in rare cases.



Tincture of root (to make, p. 292). For chronic infections, take ½ tsp in water 3 times a day.



Decoction of root (to make, p. 291). To treat throat infections, gargle with 2½ tbsp 3 times a day.



Capsules of powdered root (to make, p. 292). For colds, take a 500 mg capsule 3 times a day.

📄 **Tablets** Take as an immunostimulant for infections.

- Bites & stings, p. 303.
- Chilblains, p. 302.
- Cold sores, p. 304.
- Coughs & bronchitis, p. 310.

- Earache, p. 312.
- Flu, sore throats & tonsillitis, p. 311.
- Canker sores, p. 306.
- Urinary & fungal infections, p. 314.